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Unit 6 - Expanding knowledge on the topic

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UNIT 6 EXPANDING KNOWLEDGE ON THE TOPIC

The Importance of Body Fat Percentage in Measuring Obesity

While BMI (Body Mass Index) is a widely used tool for assessing whether an individual is underweight, normal weight, overweight, or obese, it is not without its limitations. One of the primary drawbacks of BMI is that it doesn't distinguish between muscle and fat. As a result, athletes or individuals with high muscle mass may be classified as overweight or obese, even if they have little body fat. This is where Body Fat Percentage (BFP) becomes an important measure in understanding obesity more accurately.

WHAT IS BODY FAT PERCENTAGE?

Body Fat Percentage is the percentage of fat your body contains in relation to your total body weight. Unlike BMI, which is calculated based on height and weight, BFP directly measures how much of your weight comes from fat. This makes it a more precise indicator of whether someone is carrying excess body fat, regardless of their muscle mass.

WHY IS BODY FAT PERCENTAGE IMPORTANT?

- 1 Better Indicator of Health:** While BMI only gives a rough estimate, body fat percentage can provide more detailed insight into an individual's health. Excess body fat, particularly around the abdomen, increases the risk of chronic diseases such as heart disease, diabetes, and certain cancers.
- 2 More Accurate for Athletes and Active Individuals:** As mentioned earlier, BMI may not always be accurate for those who are very muscular. Body fat percentage helps differentiate between lean muscle mass and fat, giving athletes a more accurate representation of their fitness levels.
- 3 Understanding Fat Distribution:** Unlike BMI, which is a general measure, body fat percentage can help assess where fat is distributed in the body. Visceral fat, which accumulates around internal organs, poses a greater health risk than subcutaneous fat, which is found under the skin.
- 4 Tracking Fitness Progress:** For individuals on a fitness journey, measuring body fat percentage is a helpful tool for tracking changes in their body composition. Losing fat while gaining muscle can result in little change to BMI but significant improvements in body fat percentage and overall health.



HOW CAN YOU MEASURE BODY FAT PERCENTAGE?

There are several methods available for measuring body fat percentage, including:

- Skinfold Calipers: A device that pinches the skin to measure the thickness of fat at various points on the body.
- Bioelectrical Impedance Scales: These scales send a small electrical current through the body, estimating fat percentage based on how the current travels through different tissues.
- DEXA Scans (Dual-Energy X-ray Absorptiometry): A more advanced method that uses X-rays to measure bone, muscle, and fat mass.
- Hydrostatic Weighing: A technique that involves submerging an individual in water to determine their body density and fat percentage.

